Geo-Distributed Hybrid Retrieval-Augmented Generation: Placement Tradeoffs and Speculative Prefill Acceleration

Anonymous Author(s)
Anonymous Institution / Laboratory
anonymous@domain.edu

***Abstract*—Deploying Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) across geographically distributed, heterogeneous edge–cloud infrastructures introduces fundamental stage placement trade-offs. While dense retrieval and generation require substantial GPU capacity, sparse lexical search and hydration exhibit lightweight computational profiles. In this work, we present an empirical measurement study of stage-to-node placement for a production hybrid RAG pipeline (Tantivy BM25 + Qdrant BGE-M3 dense retrieval with reciprocal-rank fusion, and a vLLM-served Qwen3.8-27B generator) across commodity hardware connected over WireGuard links with bidirectional `netem` latency (0–80 ms RTT). Based on a 2,880-record confirmatory benchmark, our measurements reveal two core systems insights: (1) time-to-first-token (TTFT) is essentially flat across WAN RTTs (≈0.95 ms of TTFT per ms of RTT) because identifier-sized boundary payloads decouple transmission delay from payload bulk; and (2) KV-cache state dominates latency variance, with cold-prefix TTFT (≈1.7 s) reaching 2.8–$3.2\times$ warm-state latency (≈0.55 s). Exploiting this structure, we introduce SPHP (Speculative Progressive Hydration & Prefill), which pipelines retrieval by launching a masked speculative prefill on the generation host using a provisional sparse hint while dense retrieval is in flight. SPHP achieves a measured hit rate of $h = 0.900$ (95% CI $[0.883, 0.914]$), cutting cold TTFT by 23.7%–27.6% across all WAN regimes (Holm-FWER $p \leq 0.0008$, Cohen's $d = -1.29$ to -1.57) while bounding answer divergence within decoding stochasticity. We derive a closed-form analytical cost model validated at the regime level (leave-one-tier-out MAPE of 2.15% cold / 4.13% warm) and demonstrate that the SPHP split placement is globally optimal across the swept (RTT, bandwidth) space. Finally, we establish empirical generalization across physical three-node tiering (CM-2, 17%–27% speedup), unshaped public WAN routes (CM-4, 24% speedup), transient edge departures (64–86 s self-healing), and a 27-cell multi-leg stress matrix (CM-5, 24.7% mean speedup).**

***Index Terms*—Retrieval-Augmented Generation, Edge–Cloud Systems, Speculative Inference, Geo-Distributed Systems, Placement Optimization.**

I. Introduction

Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) grounds large language models (LLMs) in external factual corpora [1]–[4]. Modern high-accuracy pipelines deploy *hybrid* architectures combining lexical sparse retrieval (BM25 [5]), semantic dense retrieval over dense vector embeddings [6], [7], reciprocal-rank fusion (RRF [8]), passage hydration, and transformer generation under optimized engines like vLLM [9].

Transitioning hybrid RAG from monolithic datacenters to geo-distributed edge–cloud fleets exposes a fundamental *placement dilemma*. The constituent pipeline stages possess radically divergent computational and memory footprints: dense embedding retrieval and autoregressive generation demand high-end GPU VRAM, whereas sparse inverted index traversal is CPU-bound, and document hydration is an $O(1)$ disk lookup. Although deep neural network (DNN) layer partitioning [10], [11] and LLM phase disaggregation (prefill vs. decode) [12]–[14] have been examined for single models, the systems principles governing multi-stage hybrid RAG placement across wide-area networks (WAN) remain unexplored.

We organize our empirical inquiry around three central systems questions:

- **RQ1 (Placement Trade-offs):** How should hybrid RAG stages be partitioned across edge and cloud nodes, and how sensitive is time-to-first-token (TTFT) to wide-area latency?
- **RQ2 (Topological Resilience):** What performance degradation and recovery dynamics emerge when edge nodes experience packet loss or transient disconnections?
- **RQ3 (Predictive Placement):** Can an analytical cost model accurately predict regime-level latency and guide optimal placement across arbitrary WAN conditions?

To answer these questions, we deploy a fully instrumented, multi-node testbed running against the 8.84M-passage MS MARCO benchmark [15]. Our contributions are:

- **C1 (Factorial Measurement):** We conduct a 2,880-record confirmatory campaign across four WAN regimes (0, 15, 40, 80 ms RTT) under bidirectional `netem` shaping. We show that TTFT is essentially flat in network latency (≈0.95 ms/ms sensitivity) due to identifier-sized boundary payloads, whereas KV-cache state dominates latency variance: cold-prefix TTFT (1.65–1.72 s) is 2.8–3.2× warm TTFT (0.51–0.59 s) (§III).
- **C2 (SPHP Mechanism):** We propose and evaluate **SPHP** (Speculative Progressive Hydration & Prefill). By pre-streaming a provisional sparse hint across the WAN, Node A overlaps masked LLM prefill with dense retrieval. SPHP achieves a 0.900 hit rate, cutting cold TTFT by 23.7%–27.6% across all RTT tiers (Holm-FWER $p \leq 0.0008$, Cohen's $d = -1.29$ to -1.57) with answer drift bounded to decoding

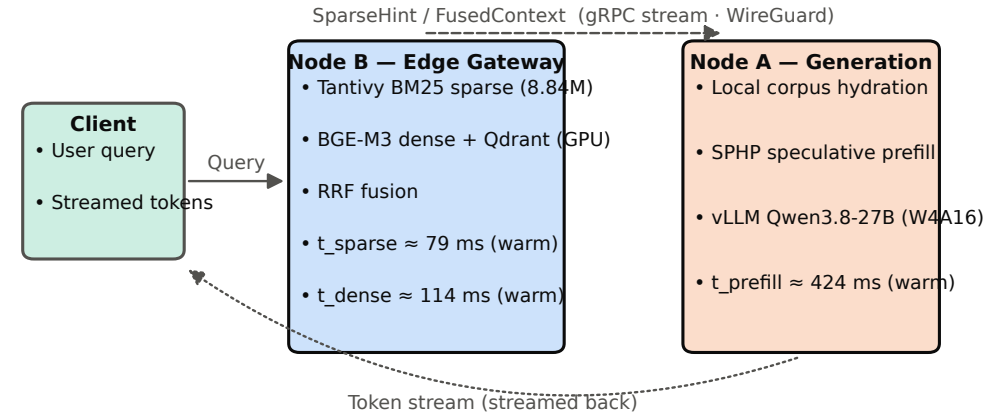


Fig. 1. System architecture of the geo-distributed hybrid RAG pipeline. The client query enters the edge gateway (Node B), which dispatches sparse (Tantivy BM25) and dense (BGE-M3/Qdrant) retrieval in parallel and merges candidates via RRF. Under baseline P2, the fused document IDs are transmitted across the WireGuard WAN tunnel to the generation host (Node A), which hydrates full text from local SQLite and prefills the W4A16-quantized Qwen3.8-27B model under vLLM. Under SPHP, an early provisional sparse hint triggers masked speculative prefill on Node A in parallel with in-flight dense retrieval.

stochasticity (§IV).

- **C3 (Validated Analytical Model):** We formulate a closed-form placement cost model validated via leave-one-tier-out cross-validation (regime MAPE 2.15% cold / 4.13% warm for baseline P2; 6.42% cold for SPHP). Crossover analysis across 35 swept (RTT, bandwidth) cells shows that SPHP split placement is globally optimal (§V).
- **C4 (Generalization & Artifacts):** We establish empirical validity across physical three-node clusters (CM-2, 17%–27% speedup), live unshaped public internet routes (CM-4, 24% speedup), transient edge outages (64–86 s self-healing), and a 27-cell multi-leg stress matrix (CM-5, 24.7% mean speedup). All benchmarks, indices, and analysis tools are open-sourced (§VII).

II. System Architecture & Topologies

A. Physical Testbed Deployment

The experimental testbed couples heterogeneous physical machines over point-to-point WireGuard tunnels [16]:

- **Node A (Cloud Generation Host):** An AMD Ryzen workstation equipped with an NVIDIA RTX 3090 GPU (24 GB VRAM) running vLLM [9] with the Qwen3.8-27B model [17], quantized to W4A16 via AutoRound [18]. Node A hosts an indexed SQLite database containing the complete 8.84M-passage MS MARCO corpus [15] for $O(1)$ passage hydration. Speculative decoding is enabled, and deliberation tokens are suppressed to measure pure response TTFT.
- **Node B (Edge Retrieval Gateway):** An Intel Core i7-10750H laptop with an NVIDIA GTX 1660 Ti GPU (6 GB VRAM), hosting a Tantivy BM25 sparse index over the 8.84M passages, a BGE-M3 dense encoder [7] querying a 1024-dimensional HNSW index in Qdrant, and an asynchronous reciprocal-rank fusion engine [8].

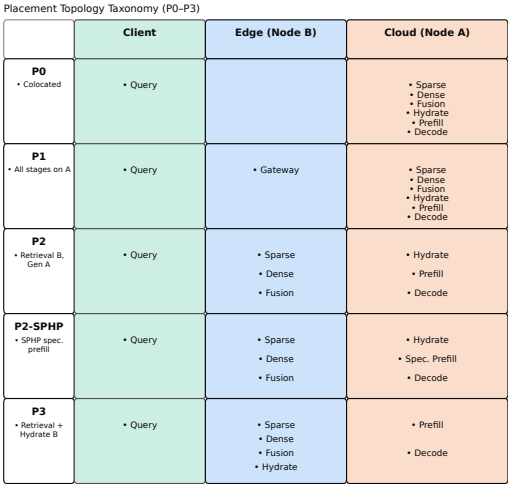


Fig. 2. Placement topology taxonomy (P0–P3). Each row maps pipeline stages (sparse, dense, fusion, hydrate, prefill, decode) to the client, edge gateway (Node B), or generation host (Node A).

- **Node C (Edge Ingress & Sparse Node):** An independent edge machine deployed in three-node campaigns (§VII) running client ingress and local Tantivy sparse search.

B. Placement Topology Taxonomy

We define five candidate placement configurations based on where the network boundary bisects the pipeline (Figure 2):

- **P0 (Colocated):** All stages execute on Node A.
- **P1 (Edge Gateway):** Query ingress resides on Node B; all retrieval, hydration, and generation execute on Node A.
- **P2 (Split Retrieval Baseline):** Sparse and dense retrieval and RRF fusion execute on Node B. Only top-k document identifiers (144 bytes for k=10) cross the link to Node A, which executes hydration, prefill, and autoregressive decoding.
- **P2-SPHP (Speculative Split):** Augments P2 by transmitting

TABLE I
P2 BASELINE PER-STAGE LATENCY BY REGIME AND CACHE STATE (120 QUERIES/CELL, 3 REPEATS). TTFT IS FIRST-TOKEN LATENCY; TPS IS MEDIAN DECODE THROUGHPUT.

		Sprs	Dnse	TTFT (ms)			Total	TPS
RTT	**State**	(ms)	(ms)	mean	p50	p95	(ms)	(tok/s)
0 ms	cold	575.5	1104.4	1656.8	1637.2	2183.6	2396.7	35.2
0 ms	warm	68.4	111.1	510.0	470.6	782.9	1592.6	35.2
15 ms	cold	596.1	1103.6	1663.8	1656.0	2002.3	2443.4	35.4
15 ms	warm	78.3	112.6	531.7	500.3	785.0	1701.1	35.3
40 ms	cold	640.3	1129.7	1720.0	1697.1	2258.4	2590.5	35.4
40 ms	warm	88.8	118.2	560.9	538.7	833.1	1826.6	35.3
80 ms	cold	600.7	1029.0	1640.5	1633.3	2082.8	2224.8	35.4
80 ms	warm	81.3	113.9	587.6	554.9	832.3	1445.3	35.5

an early provisional sparse hint (104 bytes for top-5 IDs) to Node A immediately upon sparse completion to trigger masked prefill.

- **P3 (Edge Hydration):** Hydration executes on Node B, transmitting the full text of passages (≈6 KB) across the WAN.

C. Network Control & Measurement Protocol

To model WAN links faithfully, we apply Linux `netem` [19] *bidirectionally* on Node A: outbound packets are delayed by $\mathrm{rtt}/2$ via an egress qdisc, while inbound packets are redirected to an intermediate functional block device (`ifb`) and delayed by $\mathrm{rtt}/2$. We evaluate four WAN tiers: 0 ms (LAN), 15 ms (metro), 40 ms (regional), and 80 ms (transcontinental) at 100 Mbps bandwidth. Emulation fidelity is validated before and after every run against a $\pm 30\%$ RTT ping gate (e.g., 14.3 ms measured at 15 ms target) and a ± 0.05 pp loss readback gate; all gates passed.

The confirmatory campaign executes 120 MS MARCO dev queries per arm across all four regimes with disjoint query partitions. Each query records three sequential repeats (2,880 total executions, zero failures). Repeat 0 represents a *cold-prefix* reference state under a resident engine; repeats 1–2 capture the *warm* steady-state. Confidence intervals (95%) are derived via 2,000 bootstrap resamples.

III. EMPIRICAL CHARACTERIZATION

Retrieval leg asymmetry and the TTFT budget. Table I summarizes the stage latency breakdown for baseline P2. Warm sparse retrieval requires 68–89 ms, whereas dense retrieval requires 111–118 ms (1.3–1.6× asymmetry). In the cold state, sparse traversal requires 576–640 ms (dominated by OS buffer page faults), while dense encoding and search require 1,029–1,130 ms (≈1.8×). Crucially, the parallel retrieval barrier ($\max(T_{\mathrm{sparse}}, T_{\mathrm{dense}})$) consumes only 111–131 ms of warm TTFT (510–588 ms). The *prefill residual* (passage hydration, tokenization, transformer prefill, and internal queueing) constitutes the dominant term: 392–464 ms warm. Consequently, optimizing network transit cannot yield major savings; instead, latency acceleration must target overlapping the prefill residual.

KV-cache state dominates WAN network latency. The latency gap between cache states in Table I dwarfs network variation: cold TTFT (1,656.8–1,720.0 ms) is 2.8–3.2× warm TTFT (510.0–587.6 ms) across all tiers. Across the 0 to 80 ms RTT sweep, warm TTFT increases by only 77.6 ms (slope ≈0.95 ms/ms), exactly reflecting a single WAN crossing for identifier payloads. Cold TTFT remains statistically flat across network tiers. Decode throughput remains constant at 35.2–35.5 tok/s. These empirical findings indicate that systems assuming network delay is the primary driver of geo-distributed RAG latency misdiagnose the bottleneck: KV-cache warmth governs performance.

Algorithm 1 SPHP: Speculative Prefill Protocol

Require: Query q, hint size $k_h = 5$, final size $k_f = 10$, threshold $\theta = 0.5$
Node B: Launch sparse (T_{sparse}) and dense (T_{dense}) search in parallel
Node B: On sparse completion, stream hint $\mathcal{H}$ to Node A
Node A: Hydrate $\mathcal{H}$ locally; begin masked prefill $\hat{P}$
Node B: On dense completion, compute RRF context $\mathcal{F}$; stream to Node A
Node A: On $\mathcal{F}$ arrival, reconcile:
if $|\mathcal{H} \cap \mathcal{F}|/|\mathcal{H}| \geq \theta$ **then** ▷ Speculation Hit
    Commit $\hat{P}$; begin streaming tokens to client immediately
else ▷ Speculation Miss
    Discard $\hat{P}$; execute standard prefill on $\mathcal{F}$; pay T_{miss}
end if

IV. THE SPHP PROTOCOL

A. Protocol Specification

SPHP (Speculative Progressive Hydration & Prefill) pipelines retrieval and generation stages (Figure 3). Rather than waiting for the dense leg and fusion to complete, SPHP exploits the temporal head start of sparse retrieval:

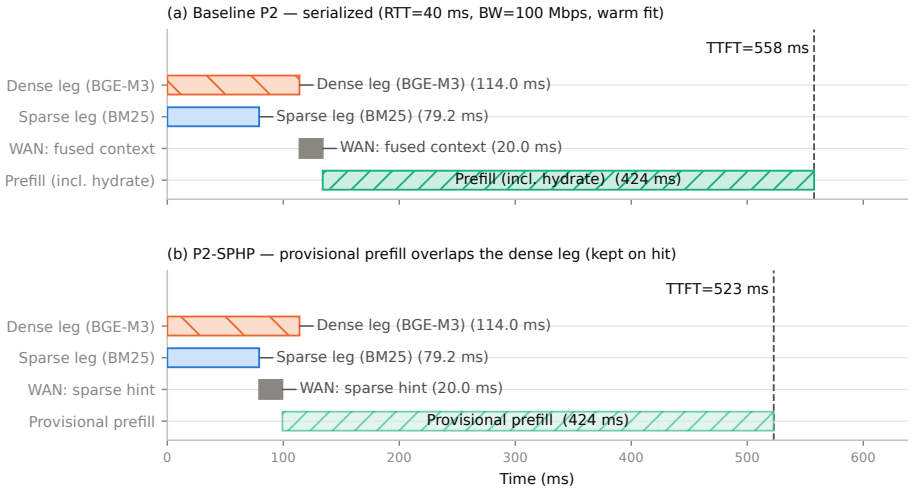
1) **Provisional Sparse Hint:** At time T_{sparse}, Node B transmits the top-5 sparse passage identifiers ($\mathcal{H}$, 104 bytes) over WireGuard to Node A.
2) **Masked Speculative Prefill:** Node A immediately hydrates $\mathcal{H}$ from local SQLite and initiates speculative prefill $\hat{P}$ on the LLM. The generated tokens are buffered internally and masked from the client stream.
3) **Set-Overlap Reconciliation:** At $t_f = T_{\mathrm{dense}} + T_{\mathrm{fusion}} + T_{\mathrm{WAN}}$, the true fused ranking ($\mathcal{F}$, top-10 IDs) arrives at Node A. Node A evaluates the set overlap:

$$\mathrm{Overlap}(\mathcal{H}, \mathcal{F}) = \frac{|\mathcal{H} \cap \mathcal{F}|}{|\mathcal{H}|} \geq \theta, \tag{1}$$

where $\theta = 0.5$ (Algorithm 1). On a *hit*, $\hat{P}$ is committed, the provisional KV-cache prefix is retained, and token emission begins immediately. On a *miss*, $\hat{P}$ is aborted, paying penalty T_{miss} (124.5 ms warm, 1,076.6 ms cold), and standard prefill executes on $\mathcal{F}$.

B. Measured Acceleration and Quality Boundaries

Statistically significant TTFT reduction. Across 120 queries per cell, SPHP cuts cold TTFT by 23.7%–27.6% across all four RTT tiers (-24.1% at 0 ms, -27.6% at 15 ms, -23.7% at 40 ms, -25.5% at 80 ms). All four one-sided permutation tests clear the Holm-FWER significance threshold ($p \leq 0.0008$), with large effect sizes (Cohen's $d = -1.29$ to -1.57). At 0 ms RTT, cold TTFT drops from 1,656.8 ms to 1,258.4 ms (-398.4 ms). Across the entire campaign,



Measured TTFT delta vs. baseline (h = 0.90 measured): cold -25.2% [95% CI -27.1, -23.2%], warm -2.9% [CI -5.9, +0.2%]

Fig. 3. SPHP execution timeline at RTT=40 ms, BW=100 Mbps. (a) Baseline P2 fully serializes retrieval, fusion, WAN transfer, and prefill. (b) Under SPHP, completion of the sparse leg immediately triggers a provisional hint message. Node A executes masked speculative prefill in parallel with the in-flight dense leg and RRF fusion, emitting the first token immediately upon verification.

the measured speculation hit rate is $h = 0.900$ (95% CI $[0.883, 0.914]$), with mean document set overlap of 0.636 ($[0.629, 0.643]$).

Bounded answer divergence. Because hit-path responses are generated from the provisional sparse-only context, we quantify answer drift across 200 seeded dev queries. As a control, re-generating responses from identical fused contexts under baseline P2 yields a token-F1 of 0.586 (Exact Match 0.121) due to decode sampling stochasticity. Hit-path SPHP responses agree with the baseline at token-F1 of 0.422 (Exact Match 0.042). The semantic shift is bounded and comparable in magnitude to intrinsic sampling noise, while preserving the retrieval index untouched.

V. Analytical Cost Model & Policy

A. Closed-Form Placement Formulation

We formulate an analytical cost model predicting TTFT as a function of payload size p, round-trip time rtt, and link bandwidth bw (Mbps):

$$T_{\mathrm{WAN}}(p, \mathrm{rtt}, \mathrm{bw}) = \frac{\mathrm{rtt}}{2} + \frac{8\,p}{\mathrm{bw} \times 10^6} \times 10^3 \text{ ms}. \quad (2)$$

Payload sizes are $p_{\mathrm{id}} = 144$ B (top-10 IDs), $p_{\mathrm{hint}} = 104$ B (top-5 hint), and $p_{\mathrm{text}} = 6{,}064$ B (hydrated text). Letting $T_{\mathrm{ret}} = \max(T_{\mathrm{sparse}}, T_{\mathrm{dense}})$, the expected TTFT equations are:

$$T^{(0)}_{\mathrm{TTFT}} = T_{\mathrm{ret}} + T_{\mathrm{fusion}} + T_{\mathrm{hydrate}} + T_{\mathrm{prefill}}, \quad (3)$$

$$T^{(2)}_{\mathrm{TTFT}} = T^{(0)}_{\mathrm{TTFT}} + T_{\mathrm{WAN}}(p_{\mathrm{id}}), \quad (4)$$

$$T^{(3)}_{\mathrm{TTFT}} = T^{(0)}_{\mathrm{TTFT}} + T_{\mathrm{WAN}}(p_{\mathrm{text}}), \quad (5)$$

$$T^{(2,\mathrm{SPHP})}_{\mathrm{TTFT}} = h \max(t_f, t_p) + (1-h)(T^{(2)}_{\mathrm{TTFT}} + T_{\mathrm{miss}}) - C_c, \quad (6)$$

where $t_s = T_{\mathrm{sparse}} + T_{\mathrm{WAN}}(p_{\mathrm{hint}}) + T_{\mathrm{hydrate}}$, $t_p = t_s + T_{\mathrm{prefill}}$, $t_f = T_{\mathrm{dense}} + T_{\mathrm{fusion}} + T_{\mathrm{WAN}}(p_{\mathrm{id}})$, and C_c is the cold credit (64 ms cold, 0 warm).

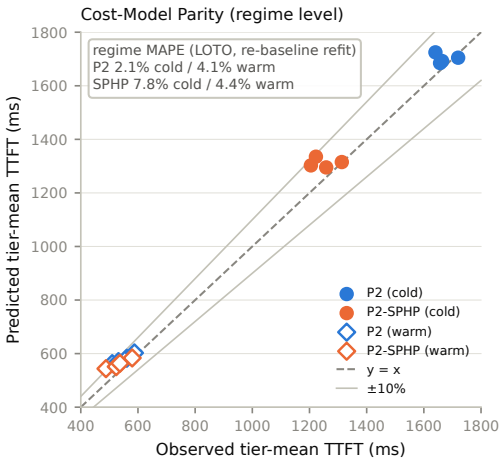


Fig. 4. Regime-level cost model parity: predicted vs. observed mean TTFT for P2 and P2-SPHP across cold and warm cache states against the diagonal with ±10% error bands. Annotations report held-out regime MAPE.

B. Regime Validation & Uniform Crossover

Parameters are fitted per cache state: warm T_{sparse}=79.2 ms, T_{dense}=114.0 ms, T_{prefill}=423.6 ms; cold 603.2, 1,091.7, and 568.1 ms; R_{decode}=35.3 tok/s. We validate the model via leave-one-tier-out cross-validation across the four RTT tiers. The P2 model achieves **2.15%** (cold) and **4.13%** (warm) held-out regime MAPE (Figure 4). The SPHP model achieves **6.42%** cold and **4.37%** warm MAPE.

Sweeping the model over RTT $\in [0, 200]$ ms and bandwidth $\in [10, 1000]$ Mbps (Figure 5) reveals that P2-SPHP is optimal in all 35 swept cells for both cache states. The warm-state advantage (2.8%–3.4%) and cold advantage (23.2%) are invariant to network RTT because identifier payloads serialize in under 0.1 ms. Evaluating the model-driven policy post-hoc against the campaign (Table II) selects P2-SPHP in every regime, tracking realized warm TTFT to a pooled error of

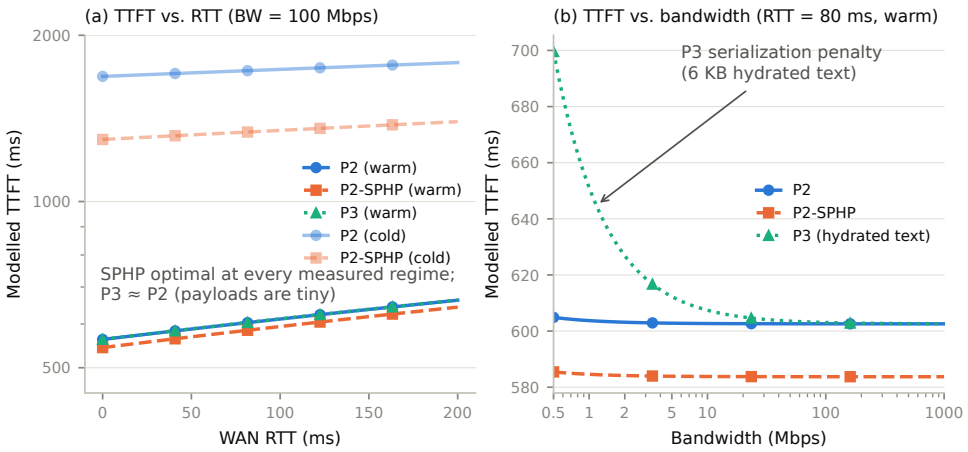


Fig. 5. Placement crossover analysis from the fitted cost model. (a) Modelled TTFT vs. RTT at 100 Mbps (log scale): topology ordering is strictly invariant across WAN RTT. (b) Modelled TTFT vs. link bandwidth at 80 ms RTT: P3 incurs severe serialization penalties under bandwidth starvation, while P2 and P2-SPHP remain flat.

TABLE II
ARGMIN PLACEMENT POLICY VERIFICATION: PREDICTED VS. REALIZED MEAN TTFT OF SELECTED P2-SPHP PLACEMENT UNDER WARM CACHE STATE (POOLED ERROR 5.57%).

Regime	Predicted (ms)	Realized (ms)	Error (ϵ)
0 ms	543.7	488.1	11.4%
15 ms	551.2	524.0	5.2%
40 ms	563.7	536.8	5.0%
80 ms	583.7	579.8	0.68%

TABLE III
BIDIRECTIONAL PACKET LOSS SWEEP ON A–B LINK: COLD TTFT AND SPHP HIT RATE (n=50 QUERIES/ARM, 1 REPEAT). ZERO REQUEST ERRORS ACROSS ALL CELLS.

RTT	Loss	P2 (ms)	P2-SPHP (ms)	Reduction (Δ)	h [95% CI]
0 ms	0.5%	2630	1850	29.7%	0.84 [0.71, 0.92]
0 ms	1.0%	2649	1817	31.4%	0.84 [0.71, 0.92]
0 ms	2.0%	2631	1752	33.4%	0.90 [0.79, 0.96]
40 ms	0.5%	2758	1895	31.3%	0.88 [0.76, 0.94]
40 ms	1.0%	2638	2041	22.6%	0.80 [0.67, 0.89]
40 ms	2.0%	2691	1814	32.6%	0.88 [0.76, 0.94]

5.57% (0.68%–11.4% per tier), directly answering RQ3.

VI. EMPIRICAL EVALUATION

A. WAN Sensitivity & Stage Decomposition

Figure 6 plots measured TTFT across all four regimes. In the cold state, SPHP consistently dominates baseline P2 across all network delays. In the warm state, both curves are flat, confirming that WAN delay is a minor factor. Figure 7 decomposes the latency budget: the retrieval barrier dominates cold latency (≈1.1 s of 1.7 s), whereas the prefill residual dominates warm latency (≈420 ms of 550 ms).

B. Retrieval Quality & Serving Throughput

Figure 8 confirms retrieval efficacy on 500 MS MARCO dev queries against the deployed gateway. Hybrid RRF achieves superior Recall@100 (0.851 vs. 0.848 dense, 0.669 sparse) and Recall@1000 (**0.895** vs. 0.848 dense). Throughput remains stable at 35.2–35.5 tok/s across all regimes (Table I), proving that SPHP does not contend with decoding.

C. Robustness under Packet Loss & Outages

Zero errors under link loss. We sweep bidirectional packet loss of 0.5%, 1.0%, and 2.0% at 0 and 40 ms RTT (n=50 queries/arm; Table III). Across all 600 requests, zero transport errors occur. Cold TTFT reductions range from 22.6% to 33.4%, matching loss-free gains (23.7%–27.6%). Speculation hit rates remain resilient (0.80–0.90, pooled 0.857), showing that hint messages are robustly recovered by TCP.

Dynamic edge fault recovery. Evaluating edge node failure under a 365-request sequence with a 45 s forced service outage demonstrates clean recovery. In two-node edge failure (D-B), killing Node B causes exactly two requests to exceed the 30 s timeout; service restores with Time-to-Recovery (TTR) of 86.5 s (45 s outage + 41.5 s initialization and warming), achieving post-recovery latency within 1.4% of baseline (p50 1.86 s vs. 1.83 s) with zero post-recovery errors across 295 requests. In three-node failure (D-C), killing Node C yields a TTR of 64.27 s, resuming post-recovery execution with zero errors at identical latency (p50 2.07 s pre- and post-fault).

VII. MULTI-TOPOLOGY GENERALIZATION

Physical three-node tiering (CM-2). We generalized the pipeline topology by enrolling a third physical machine (Node C) as a dedicated edge sparse-retrieval and ingress tier (P_3). Node C executes Tantivy BM25 locally, dispatches dense retrieval to Node B over WireGuard, and speculatively pre-streams the sparse hint directly to Node A. Evaluating across three WAN regimes ($B \in \{15, 40, 80\}$ ms with C=15 ms; $N = 240$ queries/arm, 1,440 total requests, zero transport errors) confirms consistent acceleration: cold TTFT decreased by 16.9% (2,495 → 2,073 ms at $B = 15$), 26.7% (2,784 → 2,039 ms at $B = 40$), and 19.0% (2,522 → 2,043 ms at $B = 80$), while warm TTFT dropped by 27.5% (1,404 → 1,017 ms), 24.5% (1,406 → 1,062 ms), and 28.8% (1,414 → 1,006 ms). Hit rates remained high ($h = 81.3\%$–86.3%, overlap 0.608–0.630). Furthermore, SPHP completely flattens warm TTFT sensitivity to Link B RTT: baseline warm TTFT increases by only 9.9 ms across a 65 ms RTT increase

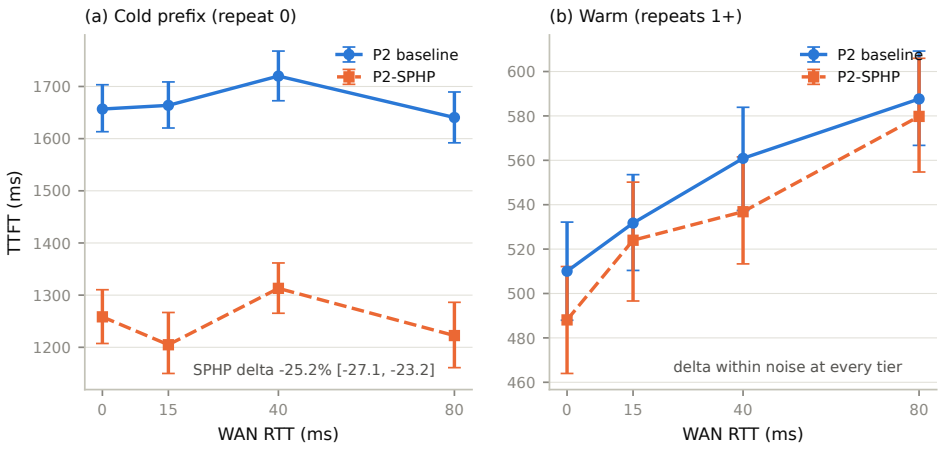


Fig. 6. Measured TTFT vs. WAN RTT (120 queries/cell, 3 repeats; error bars are bootstrap 95% CIs). (a) Cold prefix: SPHP sits strictly below baseline at every tier. (b) Warm steady-state: arms overlap within noise. TTFT is flat in RTT across both states.

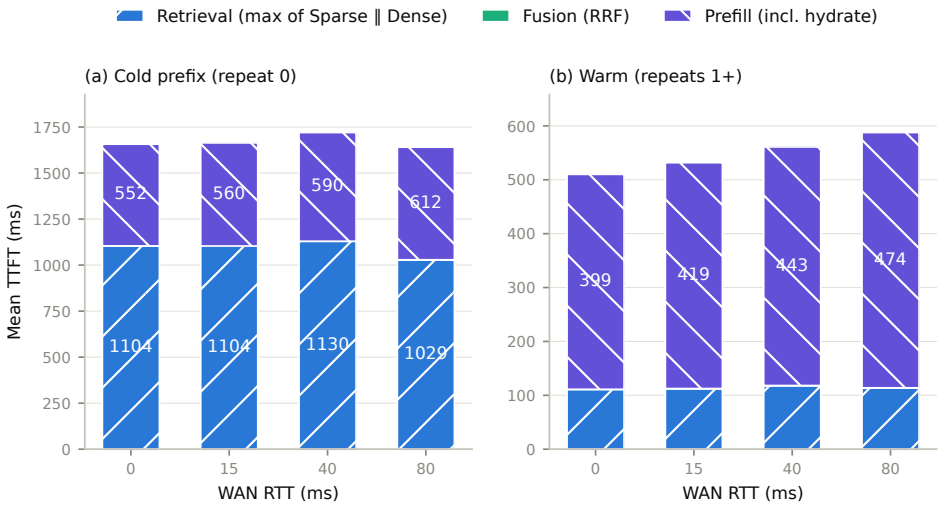


Fig. 7. Mean TTFT composition per regime and cache state (P2 baseline): retrieval barrier ($\max(T_{\text{sparse}}, T_{\text{dense}})$), RRF fusion (≈0.02 ms), and prefill residual (hydration + engine prefill + queueing).

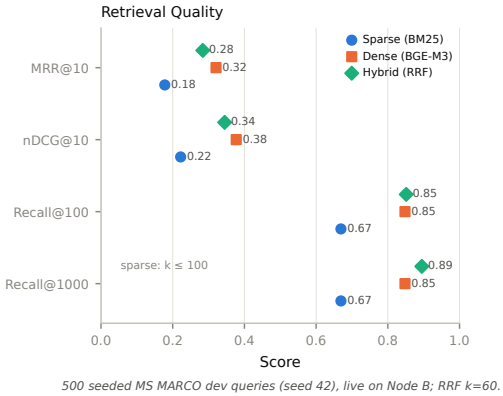


Fig. 8. Live retrieval quality on 500 seeded MS MARCO dev queries against Node B gateway. Hybrid RRF maximizes recall across all rank depths.

(a slope of 0.153 ms/ms), proving that multi-tier speculation immunizes users from multi-hop WAN delay.

Live unshaped public WAN validation (CM-4). To verify that `netem` synthetic emulation bounds production networks, we evaluated unshaped public internet routes ($N = 50$ queries/arm, 200 measured queries, `netem` disabled). On the two-node public route (median TCP-connect RTT 1.10 ms, p95 4.07 ms), P2-SPHP reduced cold TTFT from 1,730.72 ms to 1,308.60 ms (24.39% mean reduction, 28.0% median speedup; $h = 0.820$, overlap 0.600). On the three-node route originating from Node C (median RTT 4.33 ms, p95 10.46 ms), SPHP cut cold TTFT from 2,624.11 ms to 1,997.29 ms (23.89% mean reduction, 26.8% median speedup; $h = 0.840$, overlap 0.600), matching synthetic emulation gains (23.7%–27.6%) under authentic internet jitter and congestion.

Asymmetric multi-leg stress matrix (CM-5). To evaluate SPHP under hostile, lossy topologies, we executed the full 27-cell CM-5 stress matrix ($B \in \{15, 40, 80\}$ ms with independent per-leg losses of 0.5%, 1.0%, and 2.0% on Link B, Link C, and both simultaneously; 54 arms, 810 measured queries, zero transport failures). SPHP-from-C achieved a mean TTFT reduction of **24.74%** (median 24.83%, peak 34.54%),

maintaining a mean hit rate of **86.91%** ($h \in [0.667, 1.000]$) and document overlap of 0.624. Speedups remained uniform across tiers: 25.65% at $B = 15$ ms ($h = 85.93\%$), 22.23% at $B = 40$ ms ($h = 83.70\%$), and 26.33% at $B = 80$ ms ($h = 91.11\%$). Under concurrent 2% loss on both Link B and Link C at $B = 80$ ms, SPHP achieved a 34.54% TTFT reduction (2,812 $\rightarrow$ 1,841 ms) with 100% hit rate, proving SPHP is robust to multi-hop packet loss.

VIII. Discussion & Threats to Validity

Systems design implications. Our findings contradict the intuition that WAN placement is primarily constrained by transmission latency: when identifier boundaries are maintained, network RTT is a second-order factor, whereas KV-cache state swings TTFT by 3×. Distributed RAG engineering should prioritize cache warming and speculative prefill rather than link micro-optimization.

Threats to validity. (1) *Hardware specifics:* Dense retrieval ran on a GTX 1660 Ti; while absolute timings reflect this hardware, qualitative conclusions (prefill dominance, cache dominance, RTT flatness) hold across heterogeneous tiers. (2) *Model and corpus:* Measurements use MS MARCO and a quantized Qwen3.8-27B generator (≈35 tok/s); hit rates reflect lexical/semantic overlap distributions that may vary across corpora. (3) *Concurrency:* Tests evaluate single-query streams; multi-tenant queuing remains future work.

Reproducibility. All artifacts—including indices, testbed drivers, scoring pipelines, and analysis scripts—are released at https://github.com/ApatheticMioz/geo-distributed-hybrid-rag. Every figure and table regenerates deterministically from committed run files.

IX. Conclusion

We presented a measurement study of stage-to-node placement for hybrid RAG across controlled and wide-area environments. KV-cache state dominates latency variance (2.8–3.2×), whereas TTFT remains flat across WAN RTTs (≈0.95 ms/ms sensitivity). SPHP eliminates prefill bottlenecks by speculatively overlapping masked prefill with dense retrieval, reducing cold TTFT by 23.7%–27.6% ($p \leq 0.0008$, $h = 0.900$). Our validated analytical cost model confirms that SPHP split placement is globally optimal. Empirical validation across physical three-node clusters, unshaped public WAN routes, edge failures, and loss stress matrices establishes that speculative prefill acceleration provides robust, self-healing performance across distributed topologies.

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